

**Why letting go
is a high-agency skill.**

Boring Spirituality

RATIONAL SPIRITUALITY • the two axes of a person

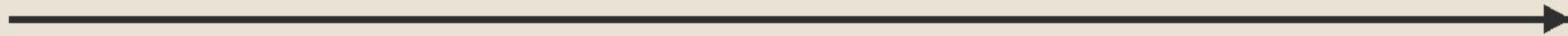
LETTING GO →

braced

released • inner agency



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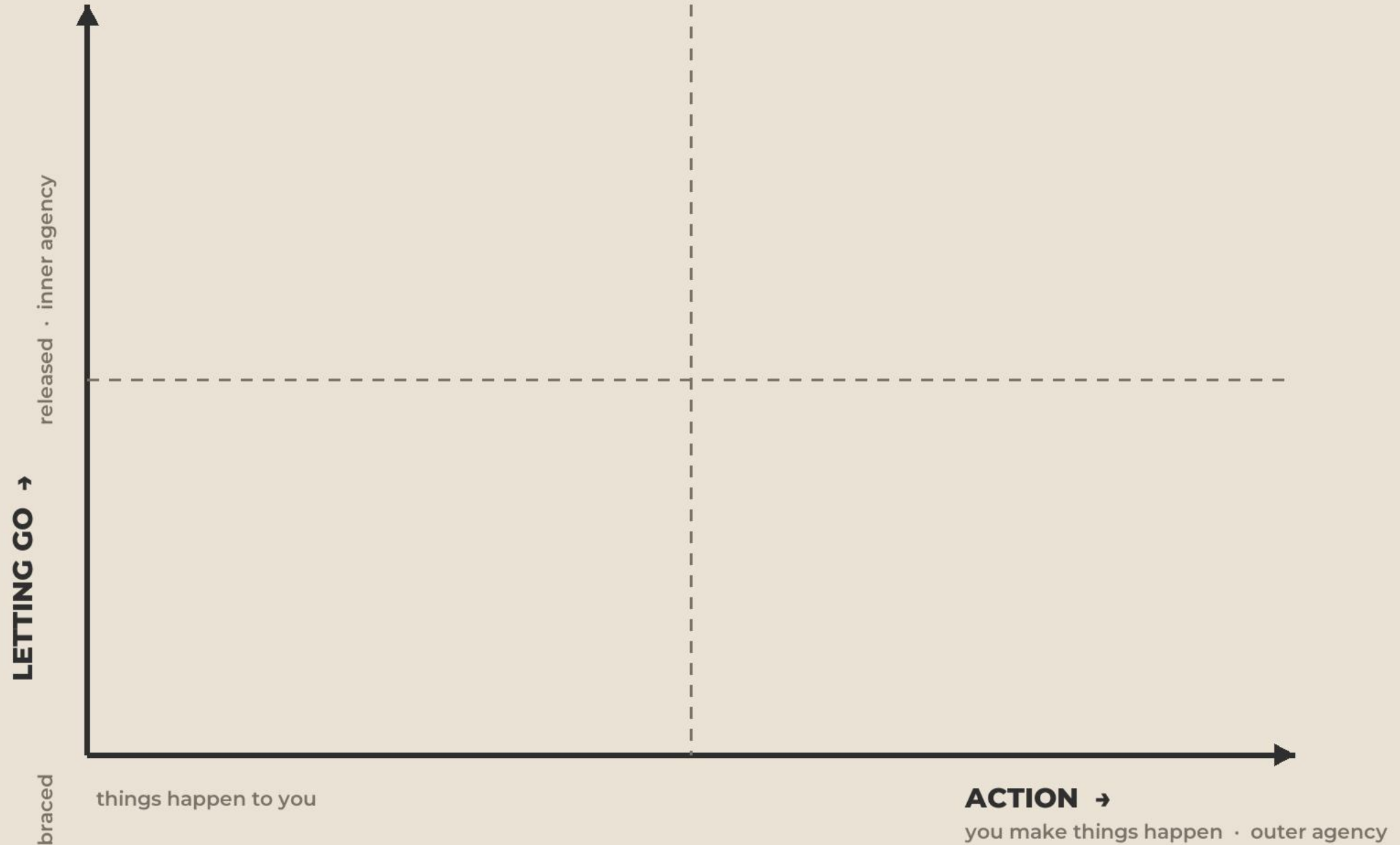


things happen to you

ACTION →

you make things happen • outer agency

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Where are you?

How many things did I say I would do, and then didn't?
How often am I the first to take the first step in a conflict?
Two questions. No belief required.

Two kinds of agency.

OUTER · doing interesting things in the world: build it, ship it, say yes, say no.

INNER · forgive. Say sorry. Admit you were wrong. Ask for forgiveness.

Take the first step in any emotional situation, with another person or with yourself.

Both are actions. Only one of them is on the x-axis. The other is how you climb the y-axis on purpose.

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Squidward Tentacles

SpongeBob SquarePants · the joke entry, but look at him

“Too bad SpongeBob isn't here to enjoy SpongeBob not being here.”

— The SpongeBob SquarePants Movie, 2004

- Tense, bitter, passive. Hates his job, hates his neighbours, keeps both.
- Dreams of the clarinet and the gallery. Practises neither enough to leave the register.
- Every problem in his life lives next door. None of it is his to fix.
- Once moved to a town of people exactly like him. Came back.
- SpongeBob is how we all start: released, active, happy for no reason. Squidward is what fears and doubts do to it.

Either die a SpongeBob or live long enough to become a Squidward.

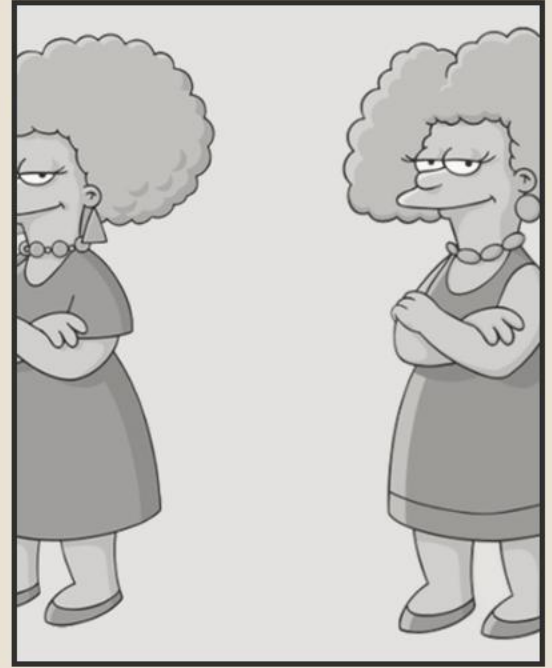


Patty and Selma

The Simpsons · the female Squidwards

- Bitter, chain-smoking, at the DMV forever.
- Every problem in their life is somebody else. Usually Homer.

Thirty seconds. Complaining is this room's native language.



George Costanza

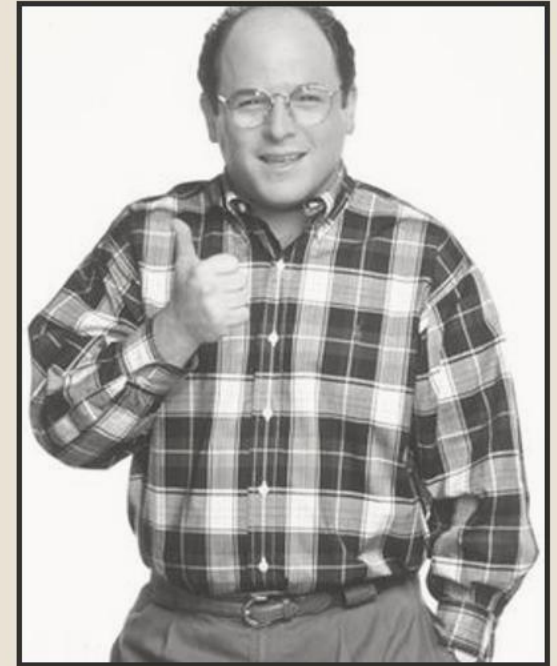
Seinfeld · tense, passive, every fear a fact

“If every instinct you have is wrong... the opposite would have to be right.”

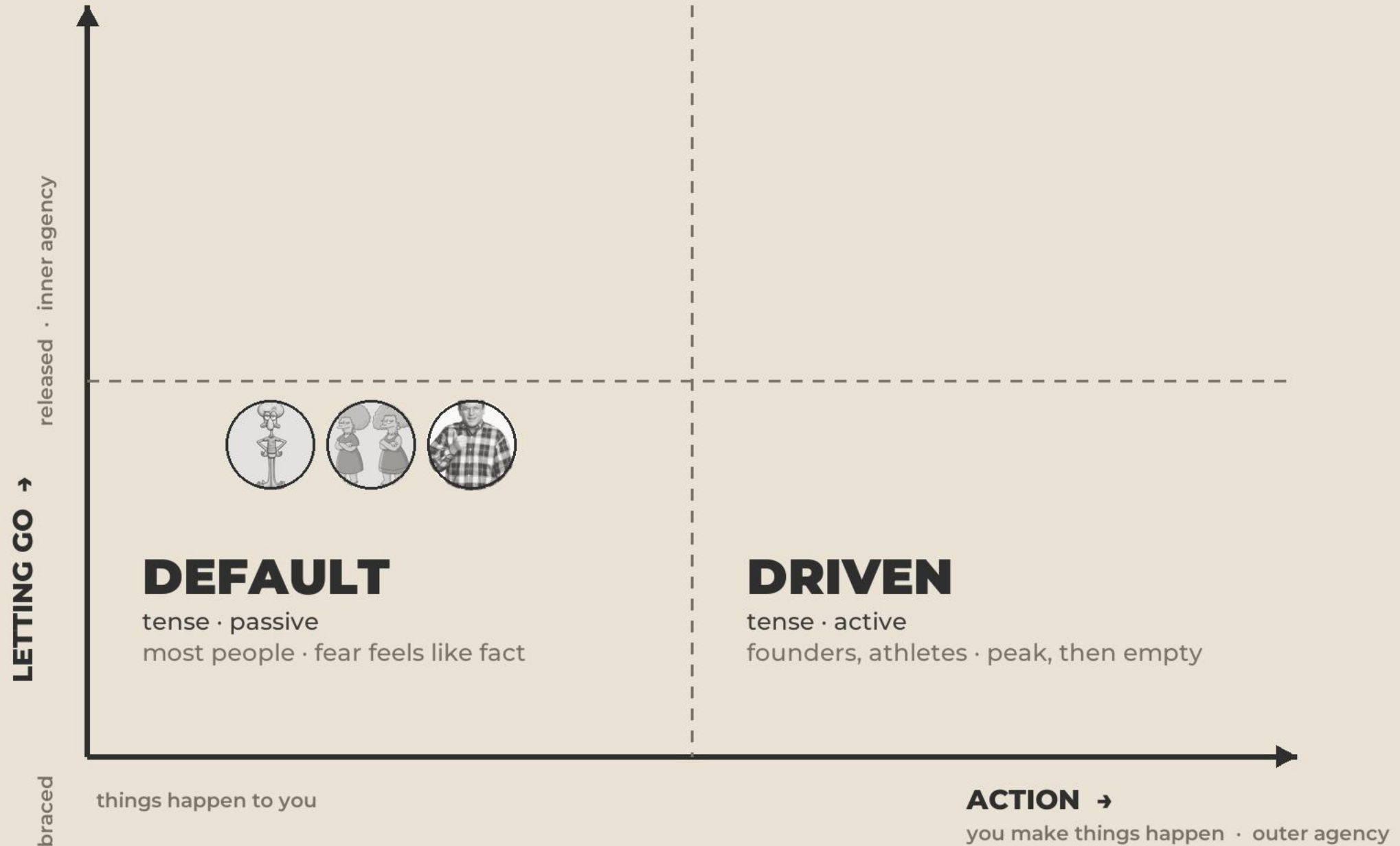
— Seinfeld, “The Opposite”, 1994

- Lives with his parents. Lies to avoid discomfort. Everything happens to George.
- Quits in a huff, then walks back in on Monday as if nothing happened.
- One day he does the opposite of every instinct. Gets the girl and the Yankees.
- It lasted one episode.

The Default room has an exit: one act against the instinct. Not a new belief.



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Jim Carrey

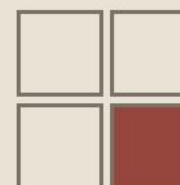
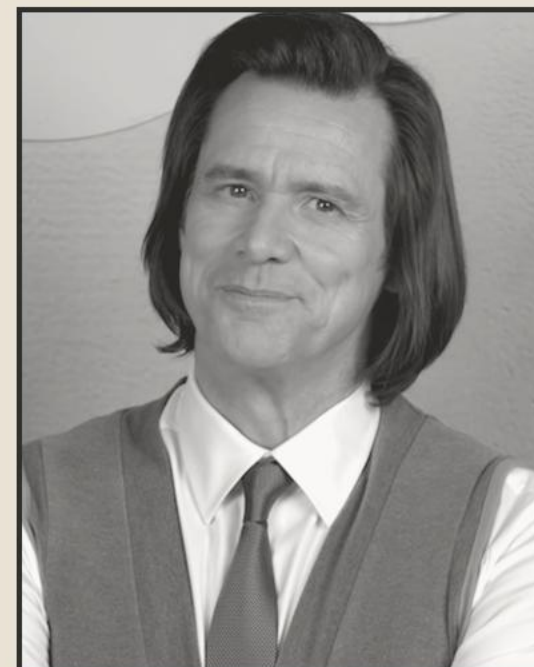
comedian · got everything he dreamed of

“Everybody should get rich and famous... so they can see that it's not the answer.”

— Jim Carrey

- Rich. Famous. Every dream on the list, ticked.
- His wish for everyone: the same, so they can see it isn't the answer.
- Peak reached. Room empty.

Success amplifies the state you bring to it. It doesn't change it.



Simone Biles

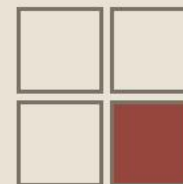
gymnast · the most decorated in history

“I have to focus on my mental health.”

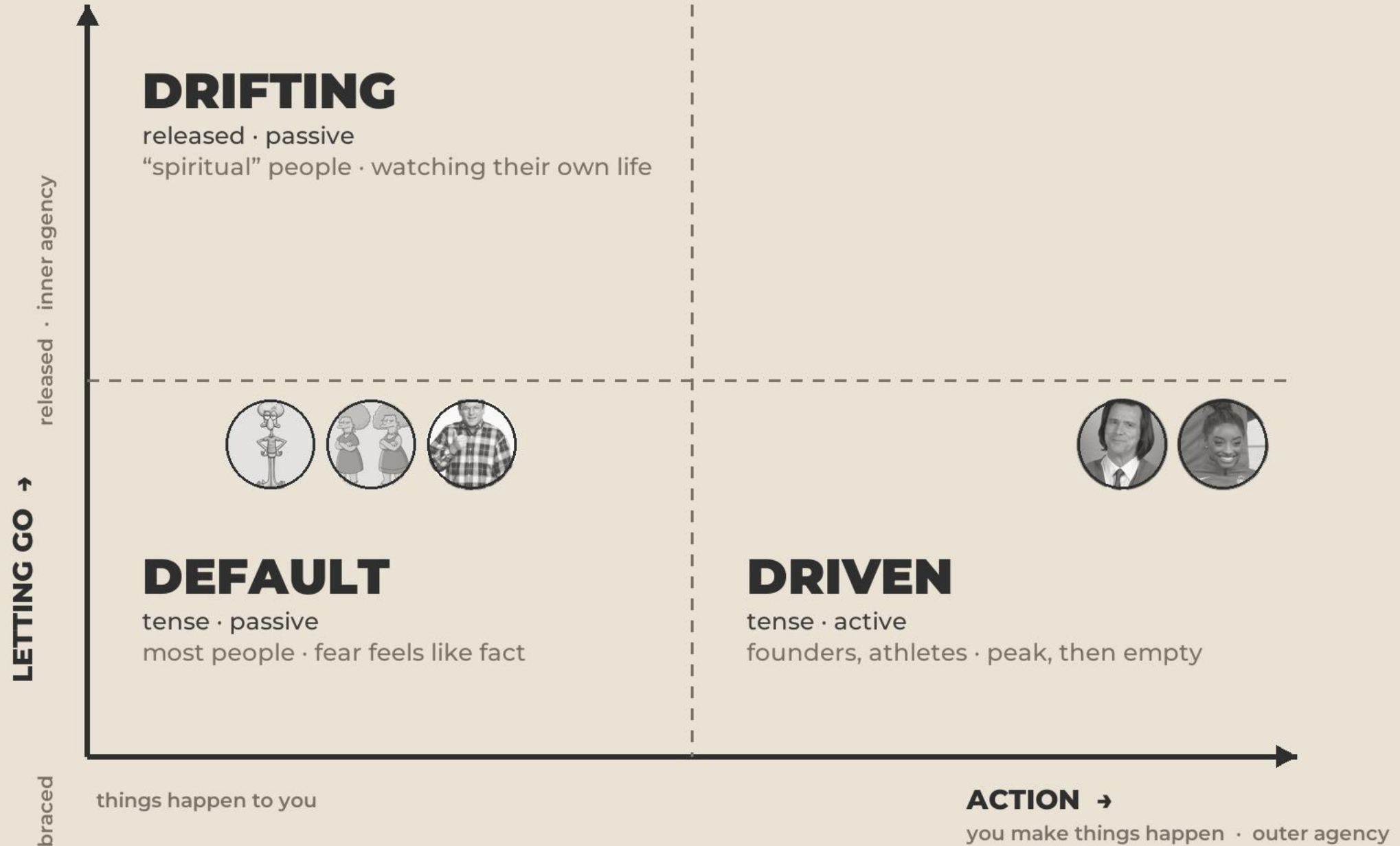
— Simone Biles, Tokyo, 27 July 2021

- Tokyo 2021: mid-air, her body stopped obeying. She pulled out of the finals.
- She said why the same day, out loud: mental health.
- Therapy. Then Paris 2024: three golds.
- Still in therapy. Still says so.

Not cured. A smaller swing, caught earlier. The drive stayed.



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The Dude

The Big Lebowski · 1998

“The Dude abides.”

— The Big Lebowski

- The most released man on screen. Nothing rattles him for long. He abides.
- And everything in his life happens to him: the rug, the kidnapping, the money, the car.
- Loved so much the world started a religion around him.

Released, beloved, and carried through his own story by other people's plans.



Phoebe Buffay

Friends · the Dude with a guitar

- Auras, past lives, Smelly Cat. Calm, kind, loved by everyone.
- Things mostly happen to her. She is fine with that.

The happiest resident of this room. Still a resident.



John Welwood

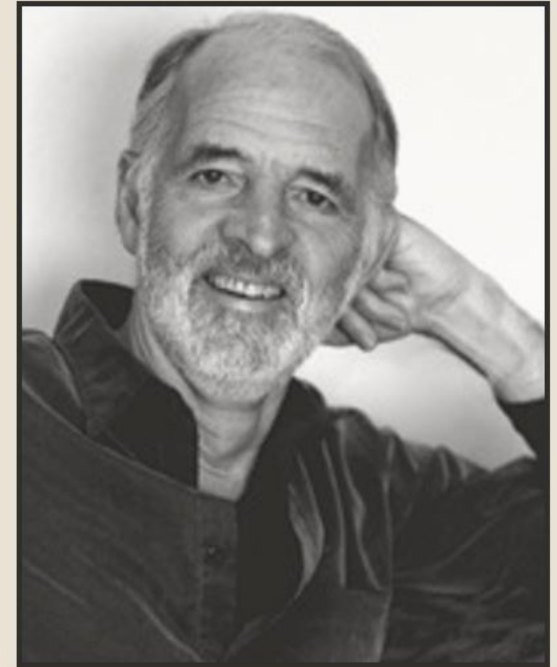
clinical psychologist and Buddhist · 1943–2019

“Using spiritual ideas and practices to sidestep... unresolved emotional issues.”

— John Welwood, his definition of spiritual bypassing

- Coined spiritual bypassing, 1984: using practice to sidestep the wounds you haven't faced.
- Numbness dressed as equanimity. Detachment dressed as non-attachment.
- “It's all perfect,” so you never have to feel it. Kind to everyone, honest with no one.
- His prescription: the practice AND the psychological work. Both legs.

A Buddhist named the trap from inside. It's a diagnosis, not a dig.



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Malala Yousafzai

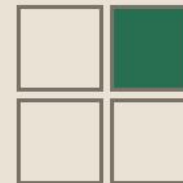
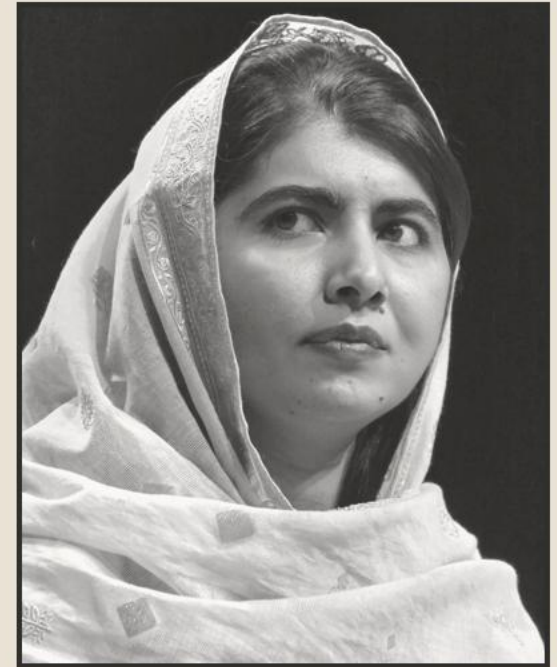
shot at 15 for going to school · Nobel Peace Prize at 17

“I do not even hate the Talib who shot me.”

— Malala Yousafzai, UN Youth Assembly, 12 July 2013

- Kept going to school under the Taliban, and said so: a blog, then TV.
- Shot in the head on the school bus, 2012. Survived.
- Built a global movement for girls' education. Oxford degree.
- And the inner leg, said at the UN: she does not hate the man who shot her.

Outer agency and inner agency in one person. Both axes, at once.



Marcus Aurelius

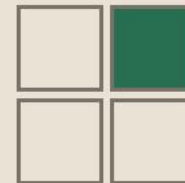
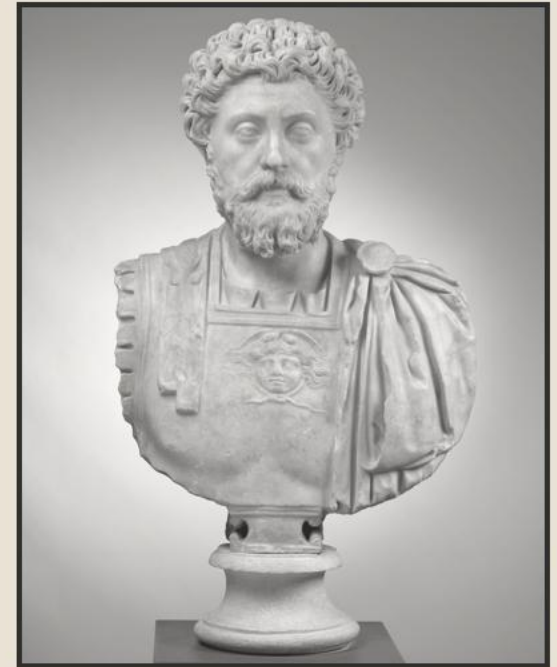
Emperor of Rome · 161–180

“What stands in the way becomes the way.”

— Marcus Aurelius, Meditations 5.20

- Plague, a long war, a general who declared himself emperor, most of his children dead.
- At night, in a tent on campaign, notes to himself he never meant anyone to read.
- When the usurper was killed, he grieved losing the chance to pardon him.

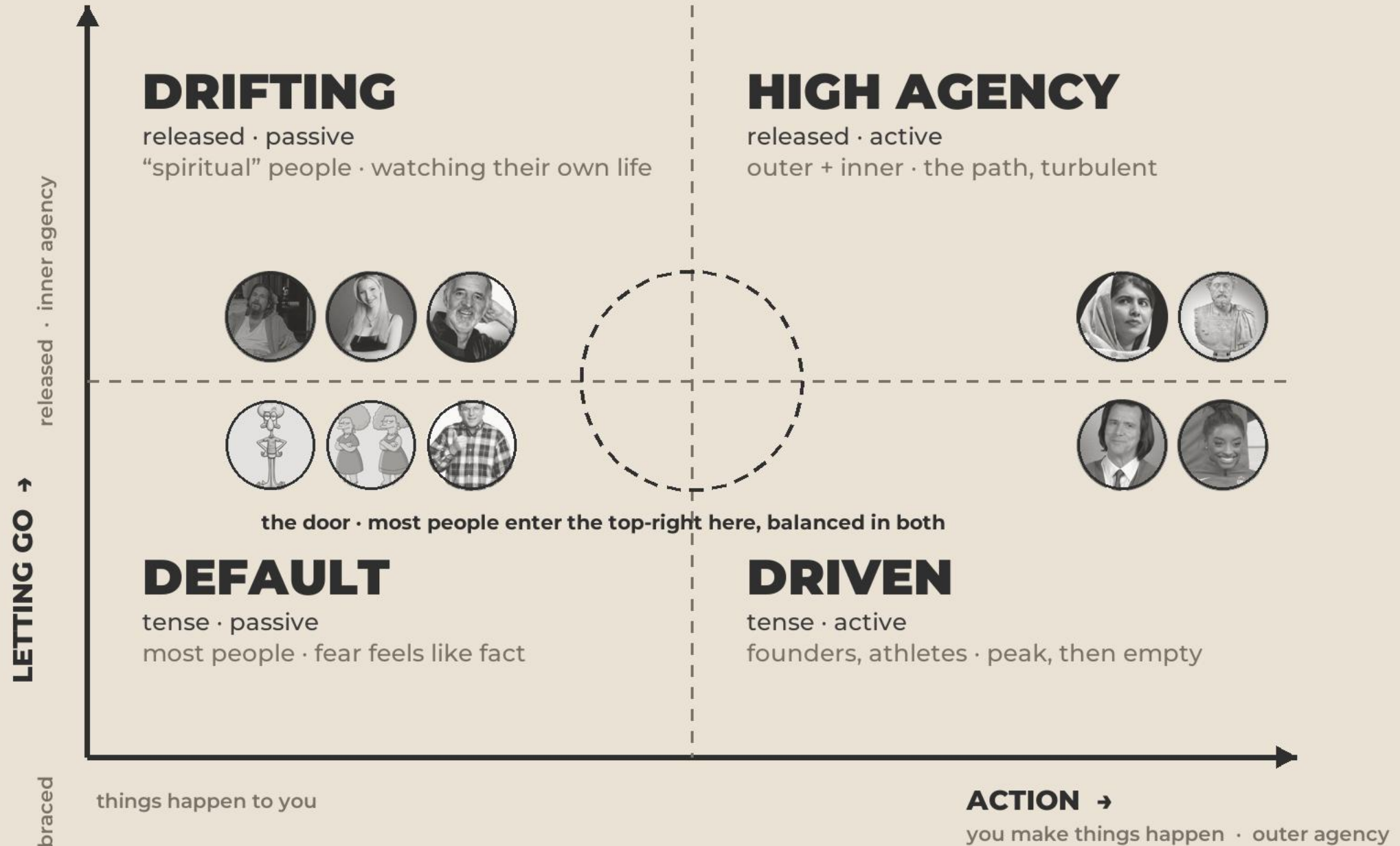
The biggest to-do list on earth, and present in every task on it.



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How people reach the door.

From Drifting: the money runs out · life happens to them · the plateau, “nothing is changing”

From Driven: the crash after the dream · a loss that stops the machine · a shift in values

From an extreme you can't turn straight toward the corner. Too much inertia.

You ease back to the middle first. Then you climb.

The gate into the top-right is a question of why.

Drifters climb for the experience. The next state, the next insight. They plateau.

Achievers climb for the gain. Money, status, being right. They plateau too.

What gets through: wanting to be of use. A goal bigger than yourself.

Change why you do what you do, and for the first time there is a reason to move at all.

Through the door, life reads differently.

Release and action stop being two things. You feel one move the other.
Cause and effect stop being cryptic: the conversation last Tuesday, their behaviour today.
You notice your own state earlier. And other people's, before they say a word.

Life in the high-agency square.

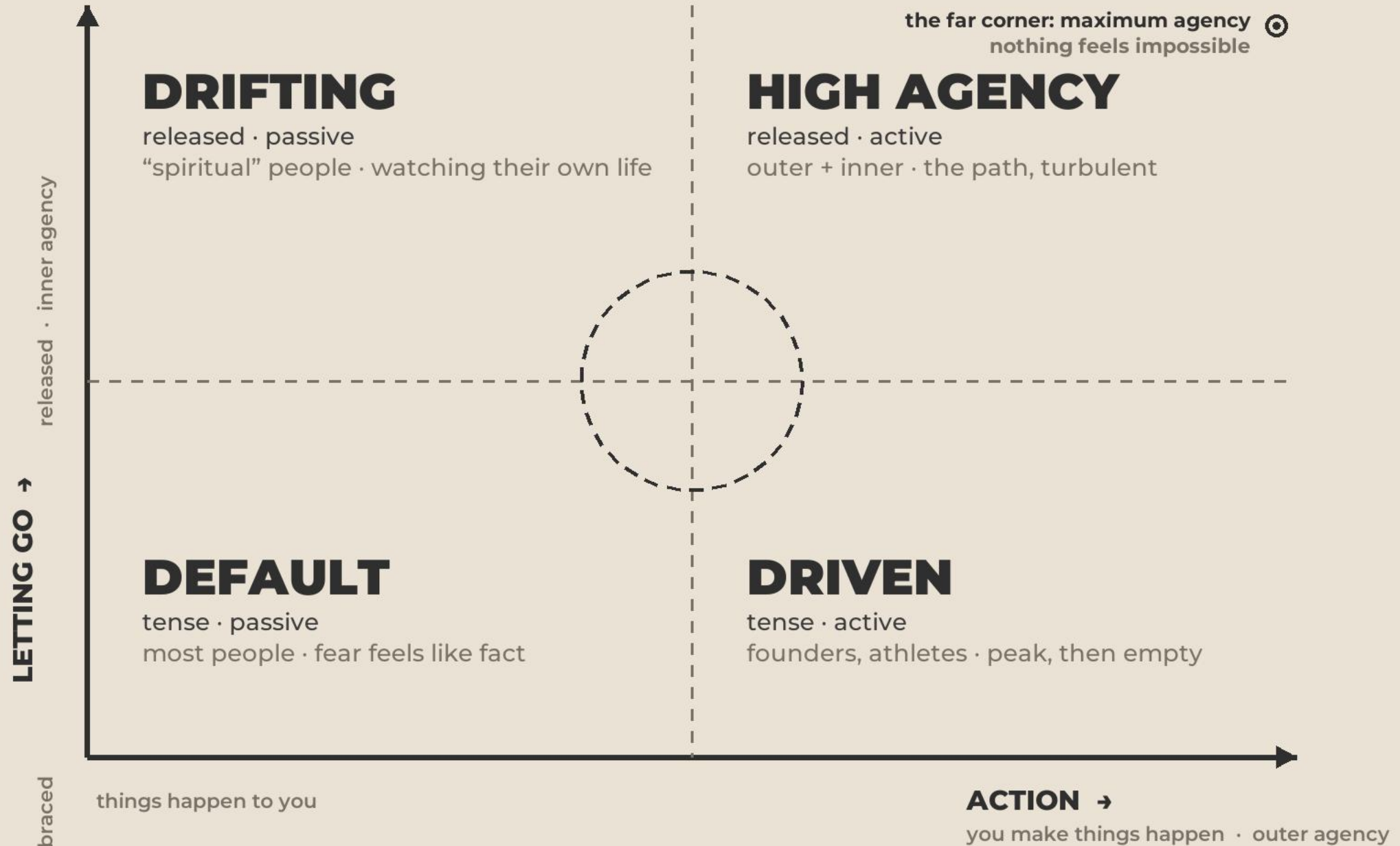
FROM INSIDE

- Present in what you do. Doing and noticing at once.
- Emotions arrive, are felt, and pass.
Reactions last minutes, not days.
- A background ease nobody can take away.
The inner critic is a voice in the next room.
- No unsolvable problems. If physics allows it,
there's a way. Decisions become experiments.
- You can receive: help, praise, rest.
Nothing to defend, so nothing to prove.
- Small things are vivid. Hard things are interesting.

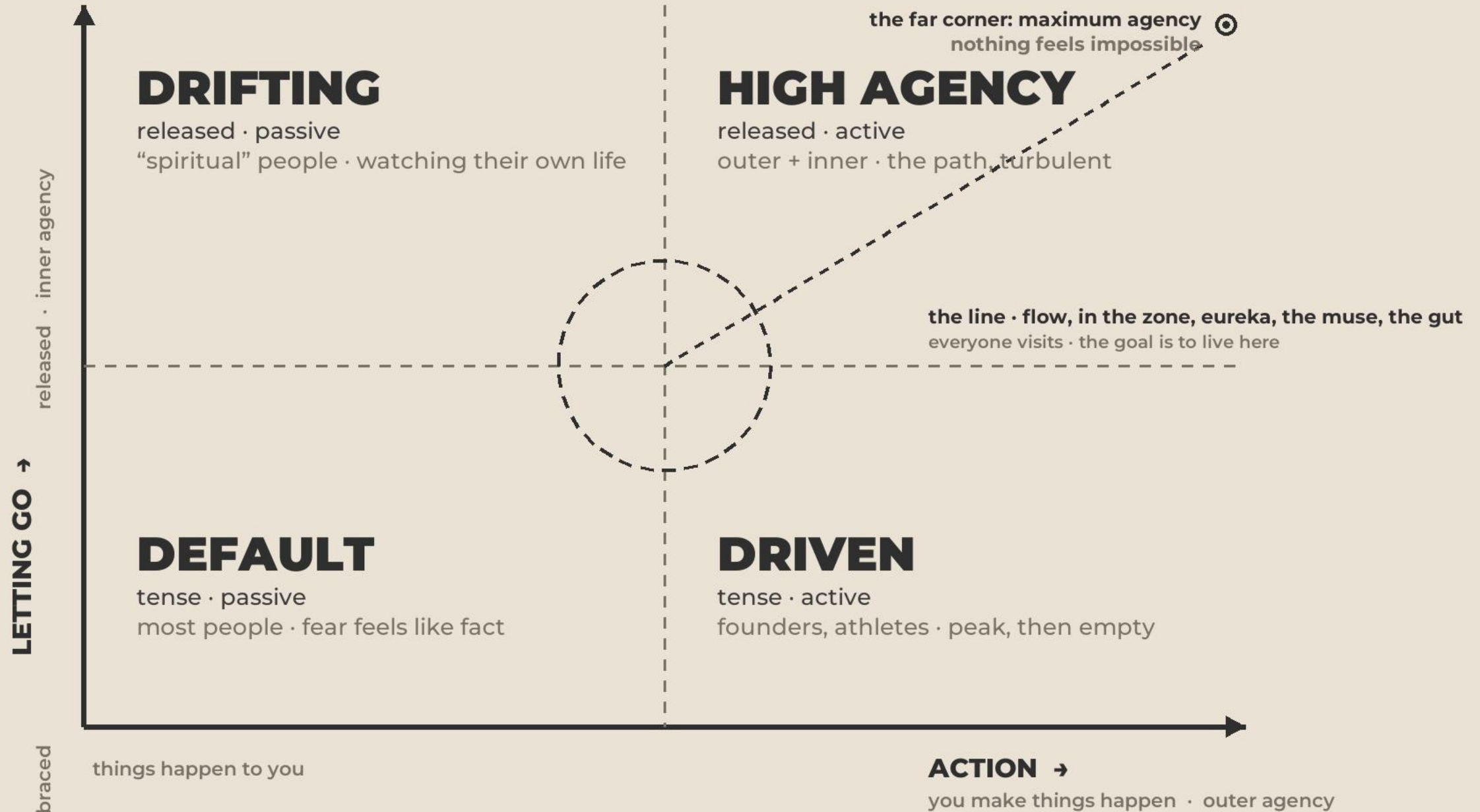
FROM OUTSIDE

- Calm but warm. Present, not intense.
People say you're steady to be around.
- The one they'd call from the jail cell.
- Direct, with kindness underneath.
You disagree without heat.
- You can hold someone else's storm
without joining it.
- They can't say what's different.
They want more of it.

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**Everyone visits.
Almost nobody lives here.**

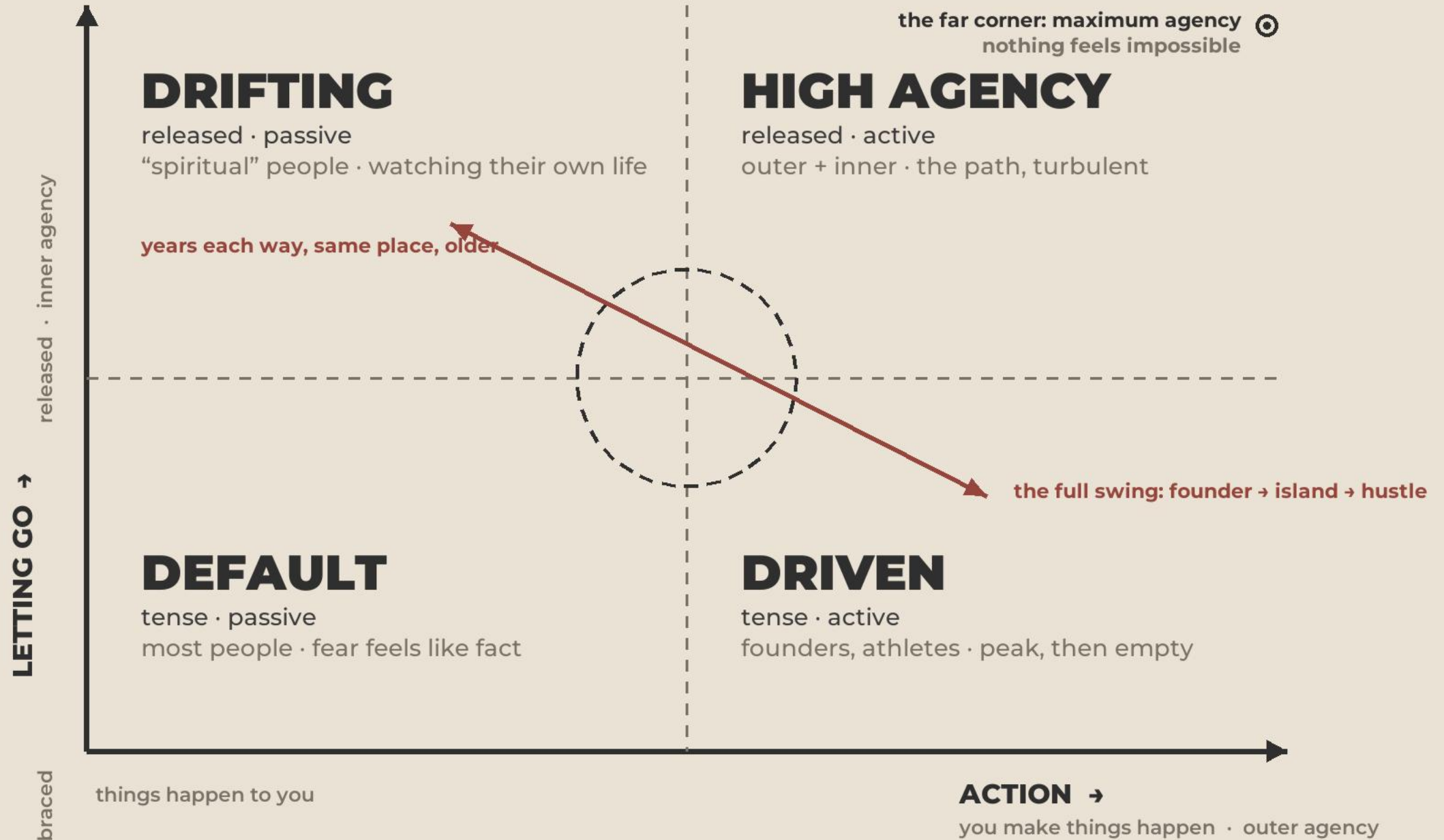
Athletes: in the zone. Musicians: the muse. Scientists: eureka. Founders: flow. Everyone else: gut.

Achievers get there through work, then go back to grinding.

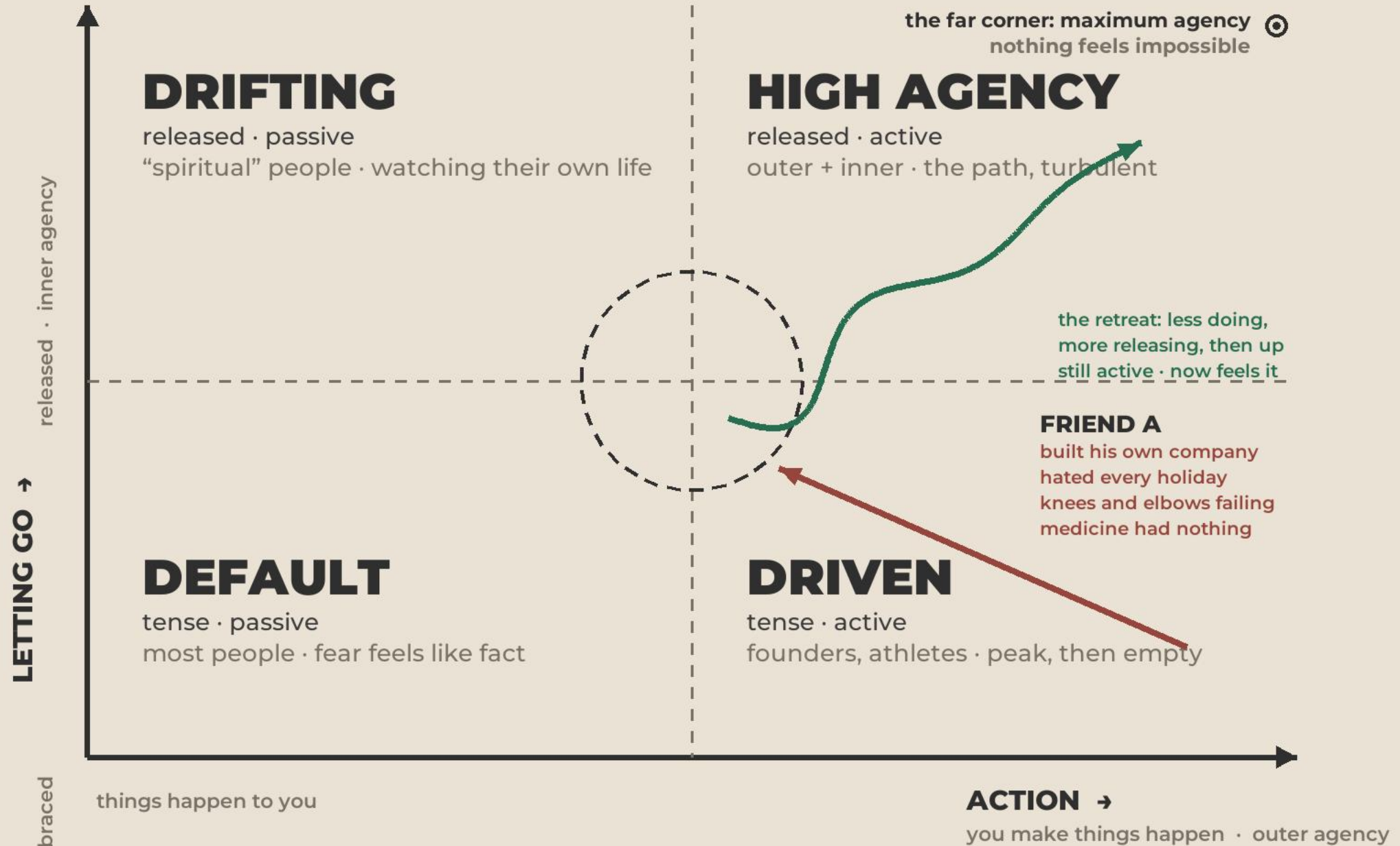
Drifters get there through a retreat, a course, a plant in the jungle, then go back to the couch.

The goal isn't to visit more often. It's to move in.

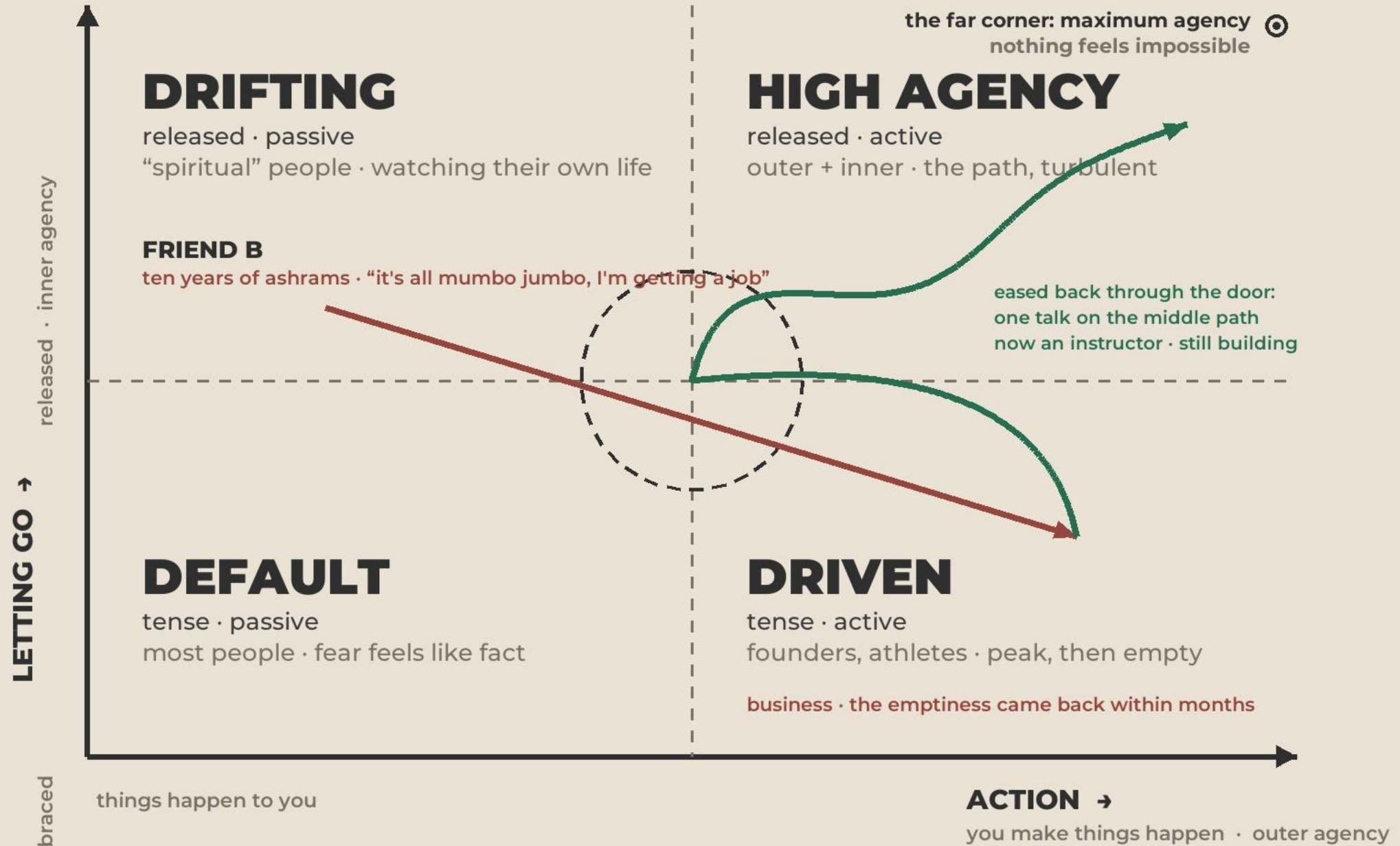
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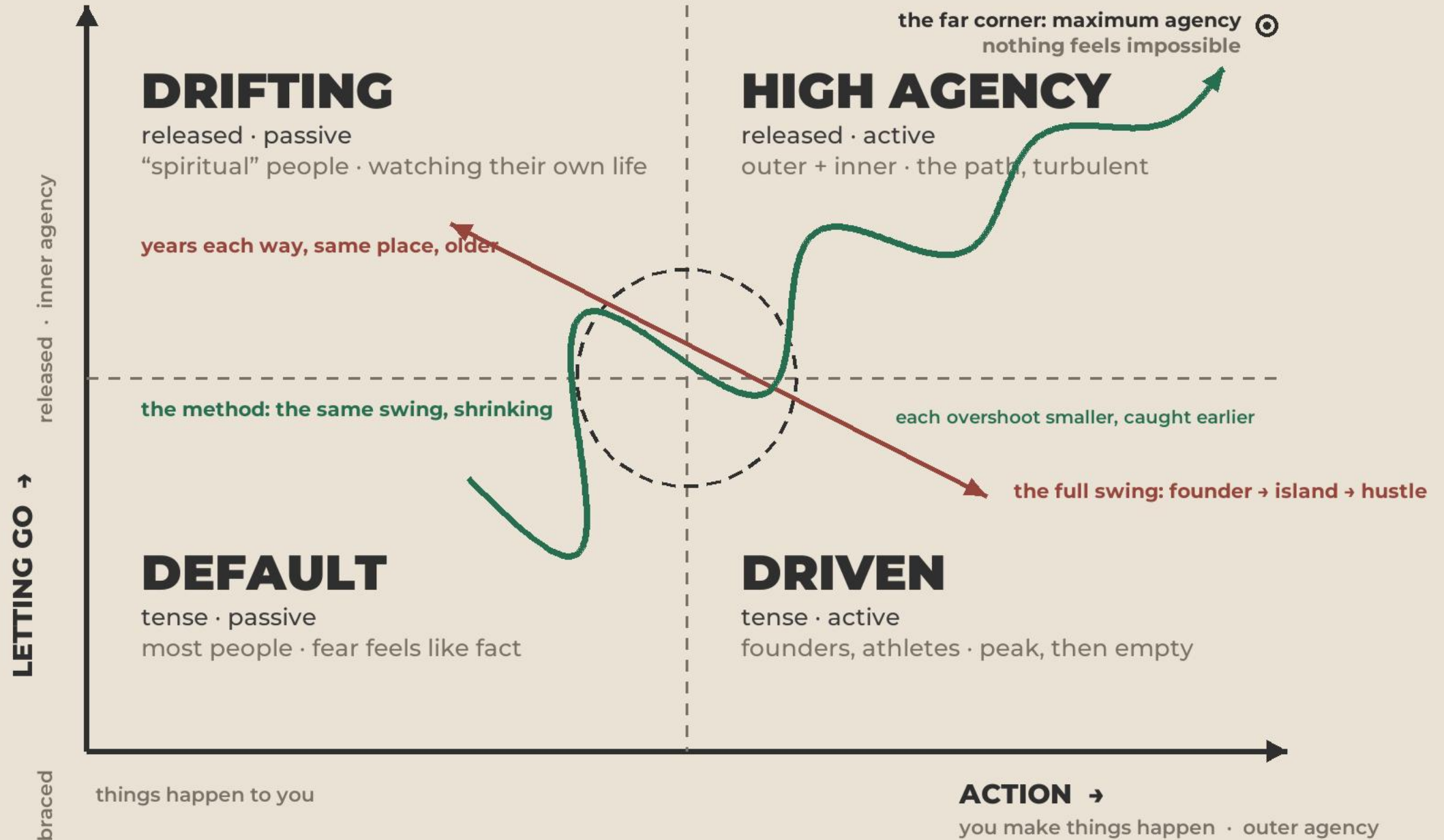
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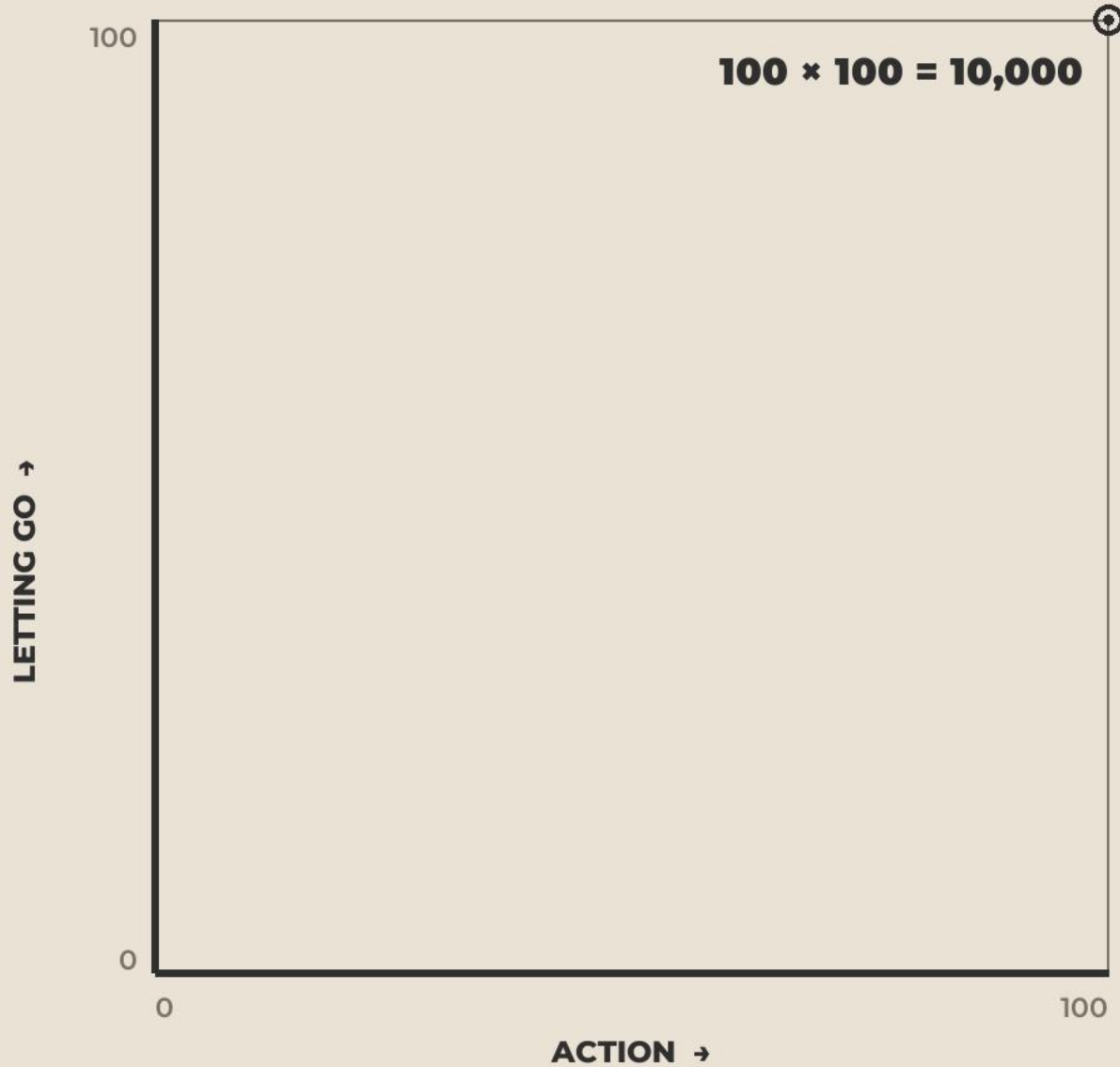
Effectiveness $\approx$ release $\times$ action.
Not plus.

100 active $\times$ 1 released = 100

95 active $\times$ 2 released = 190

Give up a little activity for a little release and you nearly double.

Not a real formula. The shape is right.

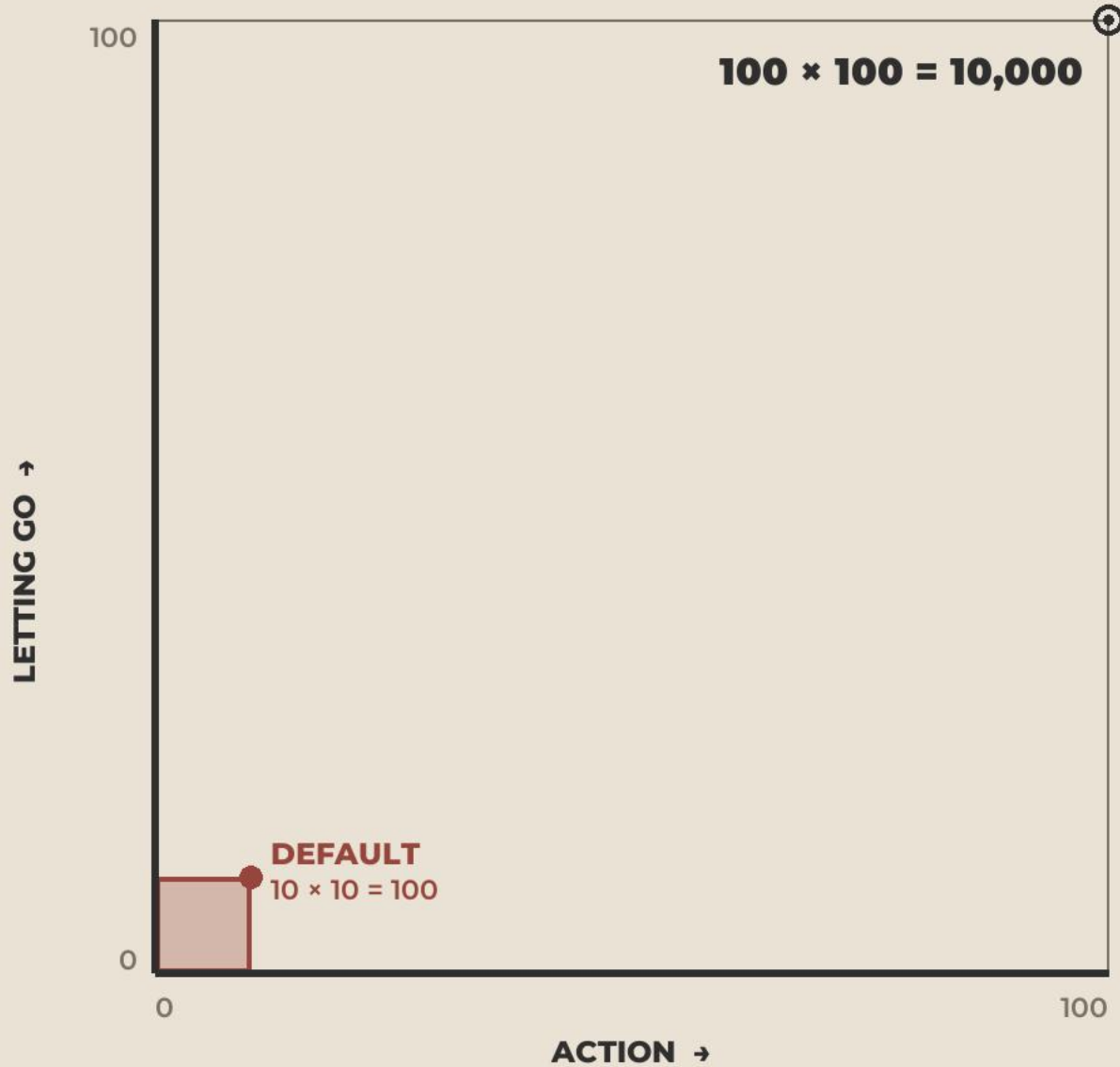


The whole square.

100 released. 100 active.

$100 \times 100 = 10,000$.

Everything a person can be, on this chart.

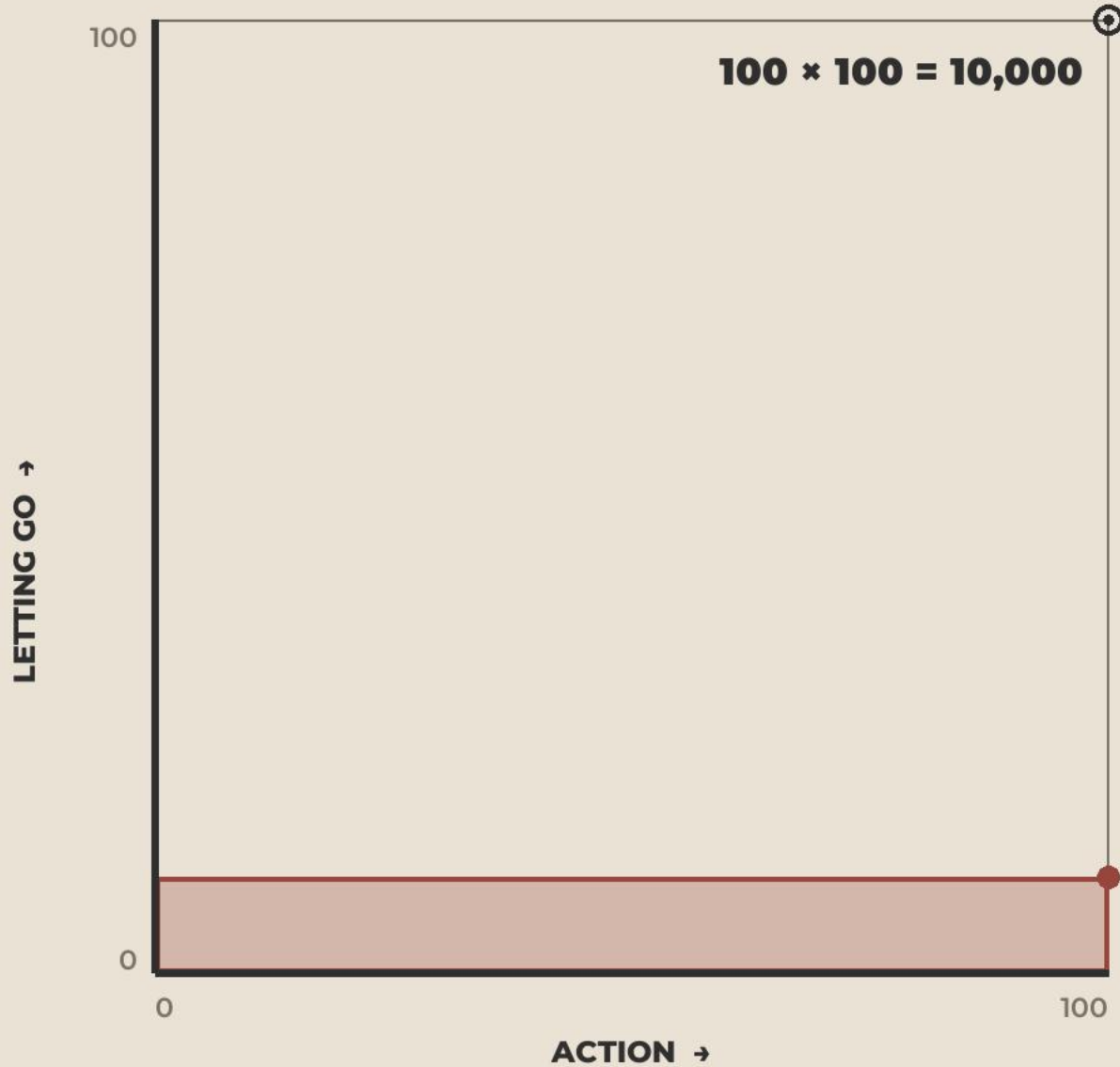


Default.

10 released × 10 active = 100.

One percent of the square.

Most people live here. From inside, it feels like all there is.

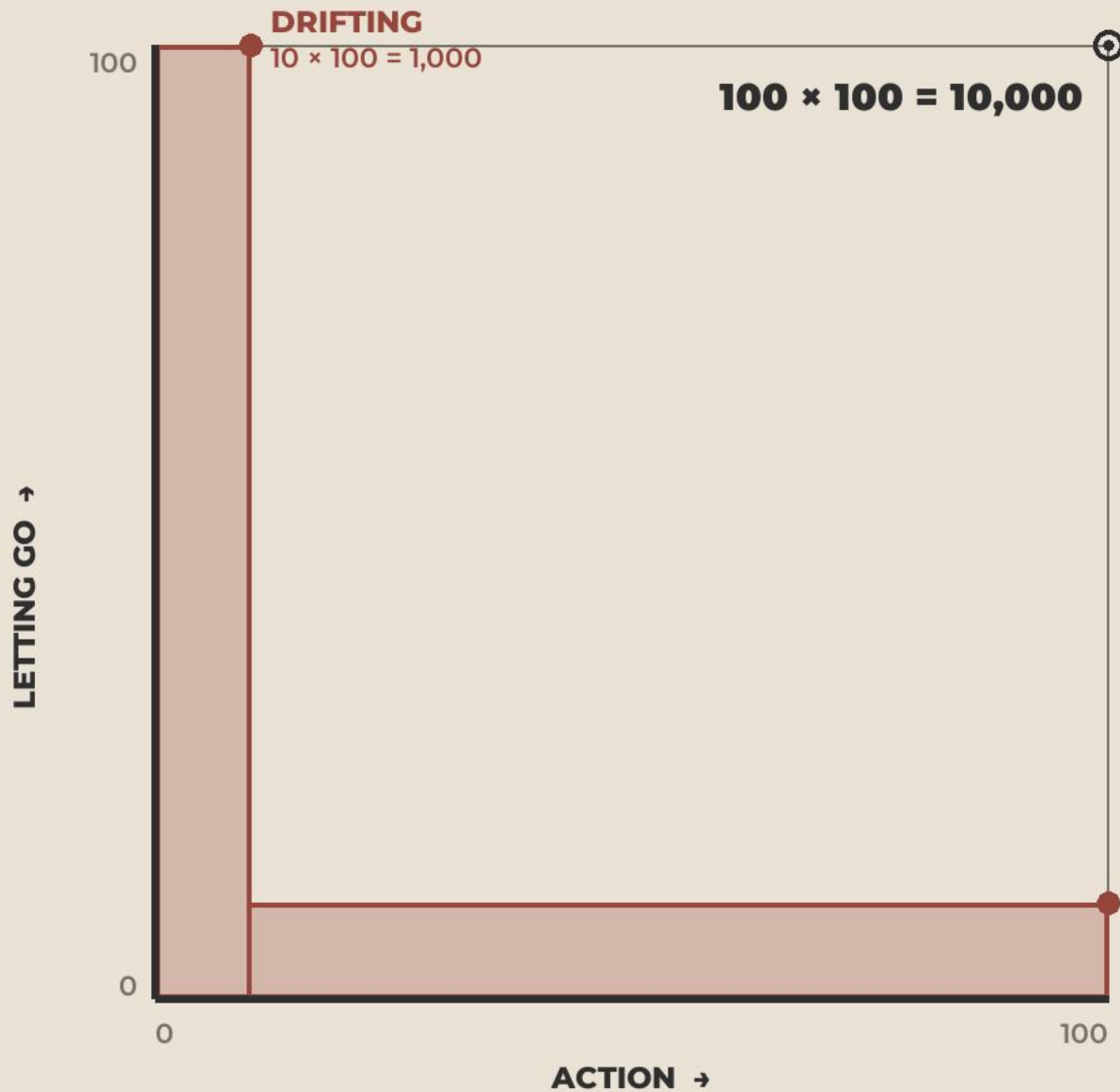


Too far right.

100 active × 10 released = 1,000.

All the way to the wall. Still one tenth of the square.

Ten times default, and it cost everything you had. The swing starts here.

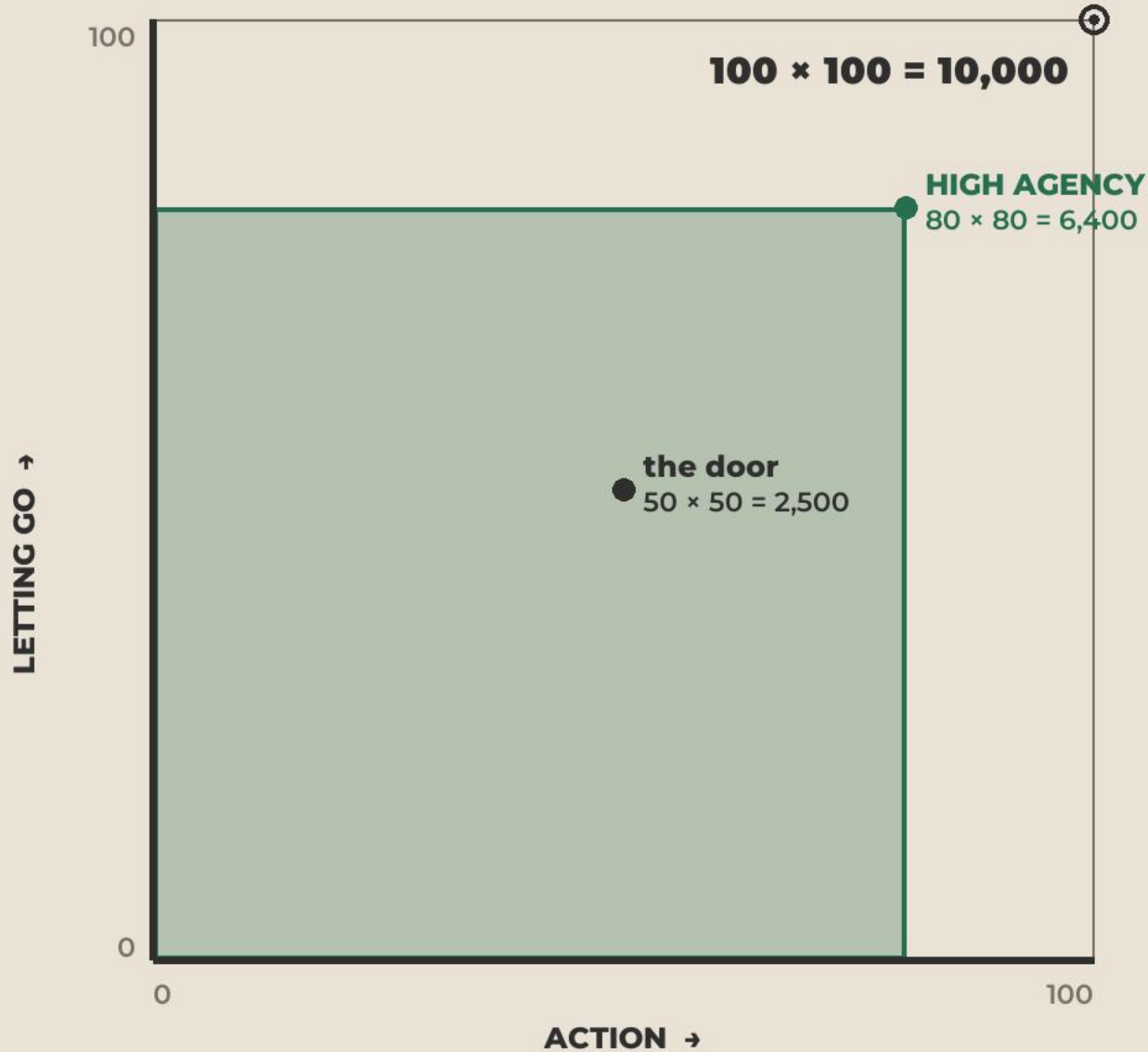


The mirror.

10 released $\times$ 100 active = 1,000.

Same size. Different shape.

The swing moves the same tenth around the room for years.



The aim.

Through the door: $50 \times 50 = 2,500$. A quarter of the square. Twenty-five times default.

Further in: $80 \times 80 = 6,400$.

The corner: 10,000. That is what we train for.

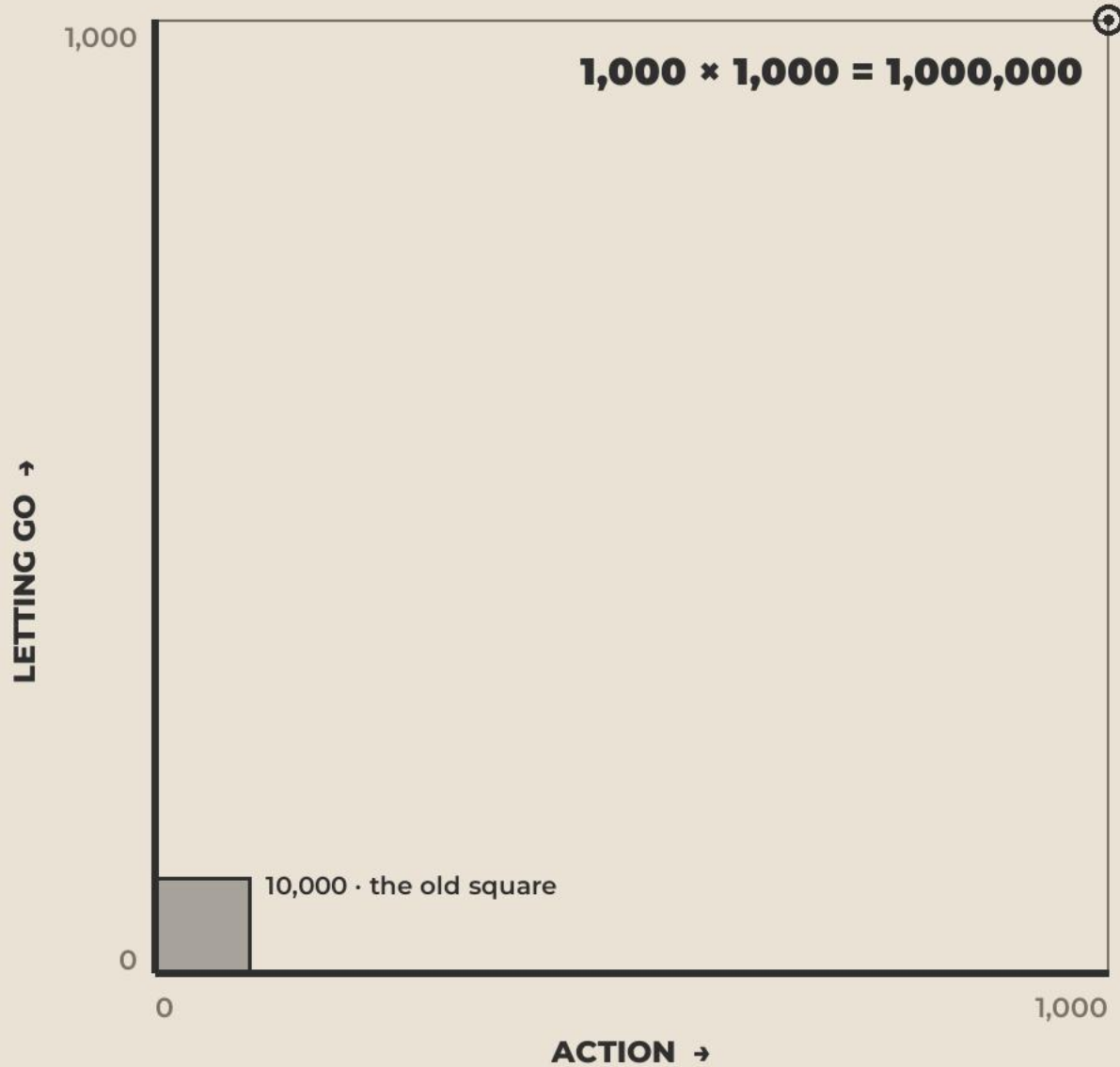
What you'll notice after.

How many options you see in the next hard situation.

How long a reaction lasts: days → hours → minutes.

The conversation you finally have.

People asking what happened to your face.



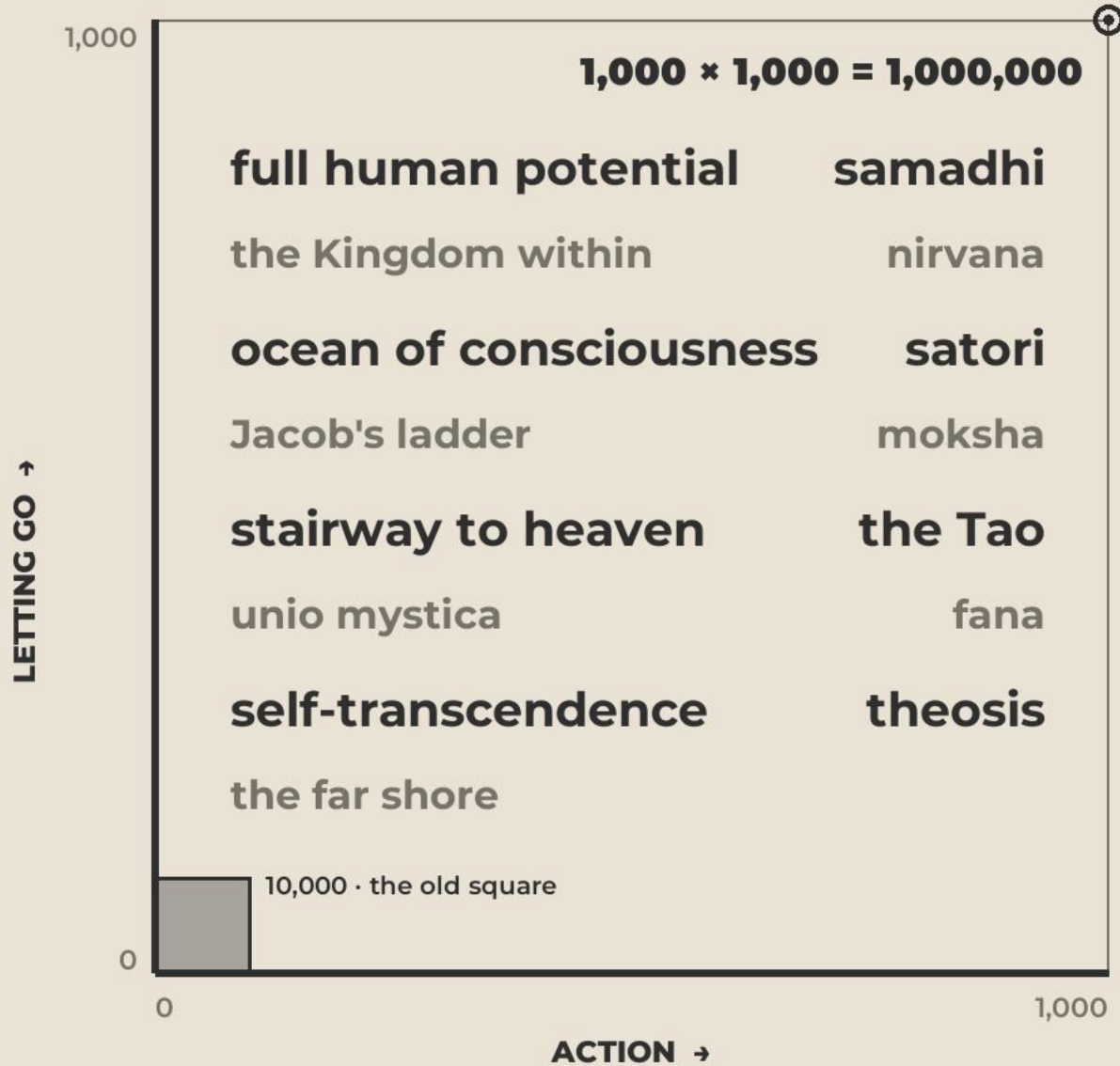
Now zoom out.

The far corner was the edge of the map.

The map is bigger.

$1,000 \times 1,000 = 1,000,000$.

That corner is where Anna and I are walking.



Every tradition names it.

Different words. Same corner.

Nobody owns it.

Come once. Judge by what you feel.

THE WORKSHOP

Saturday · 10:30 – 14:30 · \$25

Four hours, both legs: stillness, then the first step you've been avoiding.

No beliefs required.



Meditation Club · WhatsApp

scan to join · details, questions, sign-up

**In a hard situation,
how many options do I see?**

**When did I last do something
nobody asked me to do?**

When did I last say sorry first?

release · outer agency · inner agency — answer today, answer again two weeks after